

Replacing the whiteboard

BMIR is pointing participants to RideFinder instead of the ride-board whiteboard. A whiteboard can only be read by someone standing in front of it — it can't match a rider to a driver, can't tell you when someone answers, and vanishes the moment you walk away. RideFinder does all three, and it still works with no signal.

A computer station is available at BMIR for anyone whose phone is dead, dusty, or absent. Nothing needs to be installed and there's no account to create — participants can post a ride, read replies, and message a driver from that station in a couple of minutes, then pick the conversation back up later on their own phone.

1 How it works

- Browse.** Drivers offering seats on one side, riders looking for seats on the other. Filter by direction (heading in / exodus), day, city, and how much gear a ride can take. No login to look.
- Post.** Pick Driver or Rider and fill in the basics — date, 3-hour departure window, seats and gear. Posting is what creates your session; there is no signup screen.
- Connect.** RideFinder matches your listing automatically, and you message people privately inside the app.

Your session code — something like `dusty-camel-8214` — appears the first time you post. That code is the whole account. Type it into any other device to bring your listings, matches, and messages with you.

2 Auto-matching

Every time a listing is posted or edited, RideFinder scores it against every compatible listing heading the same way. It weighs:

- Date** — how close the travel days are
- Route** — not just same-city. It knows where Black Rock City is and measures the extra miles a driver would drive to collect someone en route, so a rider on the way still matches
- Gear** — whether the stuff physically fits in the vehicle
- Timing** — whether the departure windows overlap
- Freshness** — recently active listings rank higher

Each match gets a **0–100 strength score** and explains itself in plain English, so nobody has to trust a black box:

Same day Same area Gear fits Times line up

Matches are listed best-first in the **Matches** tab, with a banner on the board when new ones appear.

3 Private messaging

Tap **Message** on any listing to start a conversation inside the app. No phone number, no email address, no social handle.

Contact details never appear on the public board. Sharing is per message and off by default — tick "share my email" or "share my phone" on one message and only that person receives it, as a tappable text / call / email link. Everything else stays private, and you can keep talking without ever sharing anything.

This is the part a whiteboard can't do: no phone number written in marker for the whole camp to read.

4 Email digest

RideFinder emails from **matching@ridefinder.site** only when something actually happened — a new message, or a new potential match. Each person picks the pace:

Instant Hourly (default) Daily Never

Digests group messages by conversation and carry links that drop you straight into the right thread, already signed in — handy if you posted from the BMIR station and are reading on your phone later. Every email can change your frequency or unsubscribe.

5 It works offline

The feature that matters most on playa. RideFinder installs to a phone's home screen like an app and keeps working when the network doesn't:

- The app and the last board you loaded open **instantly, with or without signal**
- An amber bar tells you how stale the data is — *"Offline — showing rides from 23 min ago"* — so you're never guessing
- Anything you post or send while offline is queued as **"Waiting to sync"** and sends itself exactly once when signal returns. Nothing is lost and nothing double-posts.

To install: Android/Chrome — accept the "Install RideFinder" banner or menu → Add to Home screen. iPhone/Safari — Share ↑ → Add to Home Screen. Best done in town, before you're on the playa.

6 Good to know

- Free.** No ads, no data selling, no accounts. A community project.
- Deactivate your listing** once your ride is settled — it takes the post off the board but keeps your messages. It's what keeps the board honest.
- Up to 5 posts a day, 3 active per direction, so nobody floods the board.
- Listings retire on their own a few hours after the travel window; "show recently expired" brings back the last week.
- Something off about a post? Report it from the ... menu. Repeat reports hide it for review.